

Social Security in Plain English - Printable Worksheets

From *Social Security in Plain English: The 2027 Guide* by Daniel Marsh (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

C1 - My numbers

	Me	My spouse
Date of birth		
Full retirement age (Appendix B)		
Survivor FRA		
PIA (benefit at FRA, from the Statement)		
Benefit at 62		
Benefit at 70		
Years of earnings on the record (zeros in the 35?)		
Still working? Expected earnings		

next year		
Health and family longevity (honest note)		
Other retirement income (pension, IRA, savings)		
Children under 18 or disabled adult children		

C2 - The claiming-age table (my own record)

Claim at	Monthly benefit	Months of payments to age 85	Total to 85	Total to 90
62				
64				
FRA				
68				
70				

(Use today's dollars from the Statement; the COLA applies equally to every row. Break-even between two rows = money forgone by waiting divided by the monthly difference.)

C3 - The couple's strategy sheet

Scenario	Higher earner claims at	Lower earner claims at	Household monthly income while both alive	Survivor's monthly income after the first death
A: both at 62	62	62		
B: both at FRA				
C: lower earner at FRA, higher earner at 70	70			
D: our own plan				

Notes: the survivor keeps the larger benefit and loses the smaller. Spousal top-up = half the higher earner's PIA minus the lower earner's own PIA (if positive), reduced if claimed before the lower earner's FRA, and only once the higher earner has filed.

C4 - Widow's or widower's switching sheet

	Amount
My own benefit at 62	
My own benefit at FRA	
My own benefit at 70	
Survivor benefit at 60	
Survivor benefit at survivor FRA	
The larger long-run benefit is: (own at 70 / survivor at FRA)	
Plan: take the smaller first at age _____; switch to the larger at age _____	
Am I working? Earnings next year against the test limit	
Remarriage plans, and my age at the wedding	

C5 - Earnings test estimate (under FRA)

Expected wages and net self-employment next year	
Limit (\$24,480 in 2026; \$65,160 in the FRA year)	
Excess	
Withheld (\$1 per \$2, or \$1 per \$3 in the FRA year)	
My monthly benefit	
Months of checks withheld (withheld amount / monthly benefit, rounded up)	
Reported the estimate to the SSA on	

C6 - Taxes on benefits estimate

Adjusted gross income excluding Social Security	
Tax-exempt interest	
Half of Social Security benefits	
Provisional income (sum)	
Threshold for my filing status (\$25,000 / \$32,000; \$34,000 / \$44,000)	
Portion of benefits potentially taxable (none / up to 50% / up to 85%)	
Senior deduction available (\$6,000 per person 65+, phasing out above \$75,000 / \$150,000)	
Withholding requested (W- 4V): 7% / 10% / 12% / 22%	

C7 - Application checklist

Item	Done
Online account created; Statement and earnings record checked	
Errors in the earnings record corrected (W-2s sent)	
Claiming age decided (worksheets C2-C4); start month: _____	
Spouse's filing status known (spousal benefit requires it)	
Documents: birth certificate; marriage / divorce / death certificates; DD-214; W-2	
Bank details for direct deposit	
Applied on _____ (online / phone / office); application number	
Retroactive benefits declined (unless intended)	
Tax withholding: W-4V filed	
Medicare decision made separately (Part A; Part B unless employer coverage)	
Award letter received; amount checked against the Statement	
First payment date	

C8 - Appeal and overpayment log

Date	Notice about	Deadline (60 days)	Action (reconsideration / waiver / repayment plan / hearing)	Form	Filed on	Outcome

C9 - Where everything is

Social Security number (card kept at)	
Online account login (where written)	
Claiming date and monthly amount (award letter kept at)	
Direct deposit account	
Representative payee / advance designation named	
Spouse's and former spouse's numbers and dates (marriage, divorce)	
Person who knows where this sheet is	